NewsBank

Record, The (Stockton, CA) - October 18, 2026 - page 20
October 18, 2026 | Record, The (Stockton, CA) | Stockton, California | Page 20

OPINION

Republicans have seen this midterm before: 20 years ago

Your Turn
Merrill Matthews
Guest columnist

A Republican president is facing his second midterm elections. His popularity is in the tank, in part because he took the country into a costly, unpopular war he thought would end quickly. Inflation is too high and federal spending under his party has exploded. The economy, while reasonably strong, faces headwinds. His party could be headed for a major defeat in November.

You may think I'm describing President Donald Trump. I'm actually describing President George W. Bush in 2006, when a blue wave cost Republicans dozens of seats and handed Democrats control of the House and the Senate, along with a majority of governorships and a string of state legislatures.

History doesn't repeat itself, but sometimes it comes close. That appears to be what's happening heading into November.

Same slump, 20 years apart

By the 2006 midterms, Bush's popularity had tanked. His job approval rating in Gallup polling peaked at 90% days after the attacks on Sept. 11, 2001. On the eve of the elections, it stood at 38%. Trump's today is almost exactly the same: about 38% in RealClearPolling's average.

A major reason for Bush's slump, barely two years after he won reelection, was Iraq. On the eve of the March 2003 invasion, about two-thirds of Americans supported the war. By the second half of 2006, about two-thirds opposed it.

Trump's war with Iran never had that kind of support to lose. A new Pew Research Center survey found just a third of Americans approve of how he's handling it – and Republican support is slipping, too.

The president reportedly expected Iran to go the way of Venezuela. After the January raid that captured Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro and the June 2025 strikes on Iran's nuclear sites, an administration source told Axios, Trump "saw multiple decisive quick victories" and assumed toppling Iran's regime would be just as easy.

Bush's team had its own rosy forecast. Before the Iraq invasion, Vice President Dick Cheney predicted the war would last "weeks rather than months."

There are even more parallels. Inflation has been a headache for Trump – and for consumers. Yes, inflation hit 9.1% under President Joe Biden in June 2022. But it had cooled to 3% by January 2025, when Trump took office.

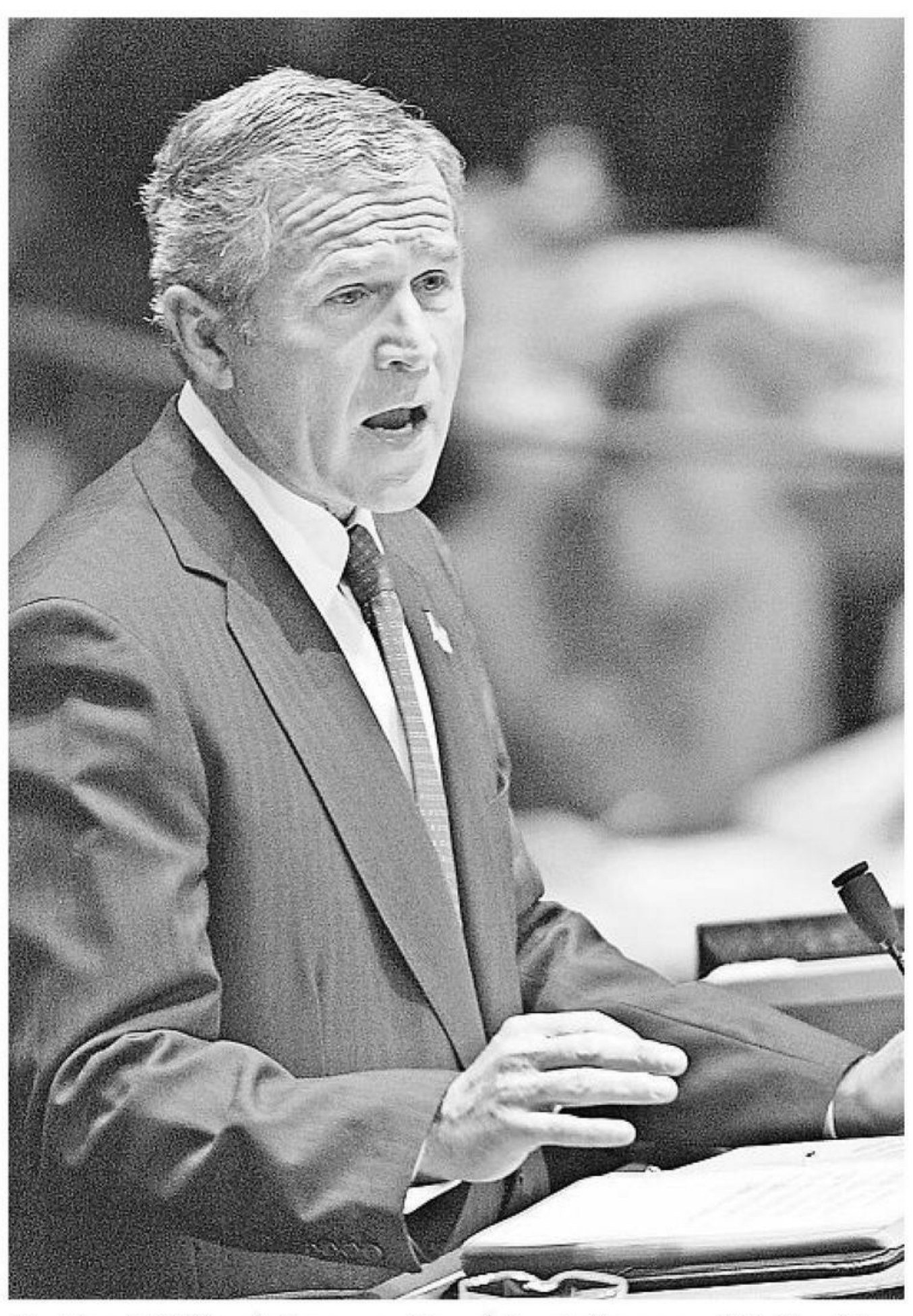
In August, it was back up to 3.4%, with gas prices doing much of the damage; core inflation, which strips out food and energy, fell to its lowest level since 2021. About 7 in 10 Americans worry the war with Iran will push gas prices higher.

In 2006, inflation ran at 3.2%, after 3.4% in 2005.

Then there's gasoline. A gallon of regular cost $1.69 in March 2003, when Bush invaded Iraq. By the summer of 2006, it was nearly $3 – about $4.90 in today's dollars. Prices fell to about $2.23 by November, but that was too late to help the Republican Party.

Trump hasn't been so lucky. Gas went from about $2.91 in February, before the war in Iran, to nearly $4.50 in May. After a summer dip, it's climbing again, to about $4.36 in September. Falling prices didn't save Republicans in 2006. Rising ones won't help them now.

Cracks under the surface



By the 2006 midterms, President George W. Bush's popularity had tanked. His job approval rating in Gallup polling peaked at 90% days after the attacks on Sept. 11, 2001. On the eve of the elections, it stood at 38%. JEFF CHRISTENSEN/REUTERS FILE

What about the economy? The Great Recession didn't hit until December 2007, more than a year after the 2006 midterm elections.

But the rumblings had already begun. Home prices had peaked, families were feeling squeezed and a growing number of borrowers were falling behind on mortgages. Those were the first cracks of the financial crisis.

Today's economy looks healthier on paper, but it's split in two. Higher-income households, lifted by a soaring stock market, are spending freely; the top 40% of earners now account for about 60% of consumer spending, according to Fortune.

But Trump has remade the GOP around voters on the other side of that split: Two-thirds of his 2024 voters didn't have a college degree. Those are the voters Republicans need to turn out in November.

One more comparison. In 2006, Democrats led the final RealClearPolitics average on the generic congressional ballot, which simply asks voters which party they prefer, by 11.5 percentage points. They went on to win the national House vote by about 8.

Today, with a few weeks to go, Democrats lead RealClearPolling's average by ... wait for it ... 8.3 points. That's a smaller lead than the one Democrats had in the 2006 polls, but almost exactly the margin they won by that year.

Do these parallels predict a blue wave? Hard to tell. But Republicans are pulling money out of races they now consider lost, like North Carolina's Senate race, and moving it into red states that should be safe.

In 2006, Republicans lost their majority in Congress. Democrats gained 31 House seats, for a comfortable 233, and took the Senate, picking up six seats for a 51-seat majority that included two independents.

I stayed up late on election night in 2006, watching one competitive race after another fall to the Democrats. Nov. 3 could be an even longer night for Republicans.

Merrill Matthews is the Texas state chair of Our Republican Legacy.

California needs larger rainy day fund

Jesse Gabriel and Josh Hoover
Special to CalMatters Commentary

At a moment when Californians can't agree on much, we've found common ground on something that matters: how the state saves for hard times.

One of us is a Democrat. The other is a Republican. We are united about Proposition 2, because this measure isn't about partisan politics. It's about basic fiscal responsibility, and it was developed by the people who understand California's budget best.

California has one of the largest and most dynamic economies in the world. It's also one of the most volatile. The state ranks fifth in the nation in revenue volatility because of our tax structure, but only 29th in the size of its budget reserves.

When the good times roll, state revenue pours in. When the economy faces challenges, the state is often forced into abrupt, painful cuts to programs Californians rely on: healthcare, higher education, public safety and safety net services.

Seniors, students and working families bear the brunt, often with little warning.

Prop. 2 fixes that imbalance. It doubles the size of the state's rainy day fund and requires California to save more during strong budget years, so we're not caught flat-footed when the next downturn hits.

This is a structural budget fix without raising taxes to save more. It's the type of budgetary planning we need to protect our future.

This isn't a new or radical idea. It builds directly on a framework voters approved in 2014. And it reflects more than a decade of experience with how that fund has actually worked.

Prop. 2 didn't start with politicians. It was born from budget experts, not special interests.

The Legislative Analyst's Office, California's nonpartisan fiscal watchdog, recommended its reforms, which developed during legislative hearings with input from the Department of Finance, independent fiscal experts and business leaders.

But its earliest supporters were firefighters, small business advocates, healthcare providers and education leaders — people who see firsthand what happens when reserves run dry and cuts land on hospitals, schools and emergency response.

That list has since grown because state leaders and fiscal experts from across the political spectrum have lived through what happens when California doesn't save enough.

A stronger rainy day fund would make California more fiscally credible to taxpayers. States that save responsibly don't just weather downturns better; they also borrow more cheaply and give families and businesses more confidence that the state can keep its commitments, even when the economy turns.

That's the real case for Prop 2. California is safer, steadier and more trustworthy when it saves like it means it.

Saving responsibly is not a partisan value. It's common sense. California's budget shouldn't lurch from boom to bust. Prop. 2 gives us a better way forward.

Jesse Gabriel, a Democrat from Encino, represents California's 46th Assembly District and chairs the Assembly Budget Committee. Josh Hoover, a Republican from Folsom, represents California's 7th Assembly District and is vice chair of the Assembly Appropriations Committee.

Why Californians always fight over UC

Connecting California
Joe Mathews
Guest columnist

Do you have a brilliant child who makes you proud, but is also infuriating?

So does the Golden State. It's called the University of California.

In her terrific new book, "California Dreams: The Making and Remaking of the University of California," journalist and author Miriam Pawel (my former L.A. Times colleague) tags all the bases of UC history, from the university's 1868 founding in the Berkeley Hills through its expansion into a $60 billion economic engine encompassing 10 campuses, six health systems, and three national laboratories.

But Pawel's book is really something more intimate: an examination of the fraught, familial relationship between our state and its world-class university system.

"California Dreams" is often quite moving, as it shows how the university shaped the ideas, ambitions, and people of California. Among the book's stars are the acclaimed Central Valley farmer-writer David Mas Masumoto, and child psychology pioneer Milicent Washburn Shinn, Berkeley Class of 1880, and the first woman to receive a PhD from the university.

The book charts the shifting arguments that Californians have had with each other about what they want their university to be. As UC became the world's finest public university system, each new generation of institutional leaders feared something has been lost. Each new generation of politicians fought the university. Each generation of students complained that the university was lacking.

All the arguing is the result of this fact: UC is one of the few institutions important and interesting enough to connect all of California's places and people. "In a state larger and more diverse in all aspects than many countries," Pawel writes, "the University remained one of the few forces that transcended disparate regions and groups. It was perhaps the only public institution that inspired widespread loyalty and admiration, even among those who were rejected."

In this context, present-day Californians' constant disputes about UC are reassuring — proof that the university still matters. Today's fights — over "woke" politics, diversity, and the current ban on using SAT scores in admissions — seem familiar, and less divisive, when compared to the past.

Pawel recounts how, during the Red Scare of the 1950s, UC and its Board of Regents engaged in brutal ideological purges that make 21st-century cancellations look tame. In the 1960s, long before current debates over campus free speech or political interference, the UC found itself in a 1960s vise, squeezed between Free Speech Movement student radicals and a conservative public outraged by campus disruption.

In the 1990s, UC was the central front in a statewide war over affirmative action that ran even hotter than the DEI debates of today. That battle included a voter-approved measure in 1996 to ban the practice which reduced diversity throughout an unrepresentative university system.

One reason why UC remains so controversial is that it is expected to do two contradictory things. First, it's supposed to be exclusive. UC screens the population of California (and the world) to identify the most promising students. At the same time, the university is supposed to be inclusive, equity-producing engine of social mobility in a very unequal state.

So, as California and the university system, paradoxically, grow more open and diverse, they grow more expensive and exclusive.

The book suggests that UC's true superpower is its resilience — its ability to absorb conflict, and adapt. At UC's 125th anniversary, writer Joan Didion recalled growing up in small-town Sacramento, when the state was less rich and less educated.

"That California doesn't exist anymore," Didion said. "We joined the rest of the country, the rest of the world... As we did so, some of us kicking and screaming, this university did what it has been doing for 125 years now. It provided the bridge. It provided the forum. It provided the safe house in which old and new California could be seen to be not irreconcilable."

Perhaps California and the UC fight for the same reason parents fight with children: because they're related, they're too much alike.

Joe Mathews writes the Connecting California column for Zócalo Public Square.

CITATION (APA STYLE)

(2026, October 18). *Record, The (Stockton, CA)*, p. 20. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb-newsbank-com.castatelib.idm.oclc.org/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=image/v2%3A16F66E84186091F0%40AWNB-1AB5275375BAC7A8%402461332-1AB52763888C7B28%4019-1AB52763888C7B28%40.

© Copyright 2026 The Record. All rights reserved.